

MY457: Seminar 3 Guiding Questions

2026-03-03

Paper:

Paper: Bruhn, J., Greenberg, K., Gudgeon, M., Rose, E.K. and Shem-Tov, Y., 2024. The effects of combat deployments on veterans' outcomes. *Journal of Political Economy*, 132(8), pp.2830-2879.

Guiding Questions:

1. General

- What is the causal question of interest?
- What is the treatment or “endogenous regressor?” What is the outcome? How are these measured?
- Explain the causal inference problem. Why can the authors not just collect data on deployment (and deployment duration) and their various outcomes, and run bivariate regressions?

2. Measurement and research design

- What is the unit of analysis / what are the observations?
- What is the research design? Explain it in simple terms.
- What is the instrument, how is it constructed, and what does it ‘do?’ You might consult page 2860.
- What is the level of treatment assignment, and what is the level of instrument assignment?
- What are the key assumptions underpinning the design? Do you think any of the assumptions is particularly implausible?
- How do the authors assess the credibility of their design? Is this convincing? Can you think of any other tests that might be useful?

3. Estimation, compliers, and LATE

- What does the ITT represent here? Contrast it against the ATE and the LATE.
- Define compliers, non-compliers, and defiers in this study. Do you have any concerns about these groups?
- Is compliance with the encouragement high or low? What does this mean and what do you make of it? How does it affect the magnitude of the LATE estimate relative to the ITT estimate?
- Do you have any other concerns about the study?